

IELTS Preparation Notes

Personal study reference compiled from mock test sessions and feedback analysis.
Target: **Band 8.0+** | Current estimated range: **7.5-8.0**

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1. Band Scale Reference

Band	Label	Description
9	Expert	Full operational command. Fluent, accurate, and appropriate. Complete understanding.
8	Very Good	Fully operational command with only occasional unsystematic inaccuracies.
7	Good	Operational command with occasional inaccuracies and misunderstandings in some situations.
6	Competent	Generally effective command despite some inaccuracies and misunderstandings.
5	Modest	Partial command; copes with overall meaning in most situations.
4	Limited	Basic competence limited to familiar situations.
3	Extremely Limited	Only general meaning in familiar situations.
2	Intermittent	No real communication; isolated words in familiar situations.
1	Non-User	Essentially no ability.

Typical Institutional Thresholds

Band	Typical Requirement
6.0	UK undergraduate entry (many universities)
6.5	UK/AUS postgraduate entry (standard)
7.0	Law, Medicine, top-ranked postgrad programmes
7.5+	Competitive fellowships, some PhD programmes
8.0+	Immigration (skilled worker, some visa routes)
8.5–9.0	Near-native; rarely required institutionally

2. Scoring Mechanics

Overall band = mean of the four component scores, rounded to nearest 0.5.

Component	Weight
Listening	25%
Reading	25%
Writing	25%
Speaking	25%

A single weak component can pull the overall band down significantly.
Example: Reading 8 + Listening 8 + Writing 7 + Speaking 7 → **Overall 7.5**

Key implication: Writing is statistically the component most candidates underperform relative to actual proficiency. Practising it explicitly is the highest-yield investment for candidates already at band 7+.

3. Writing Task 1 — Letter (General Training)

Task Parameters

- **Time allocation:** ~20 minutes
- **Minimum word count:** 150 words

- **Format:** Do not write addresses. Begin with "Dear [Name],"
- **Register:** Must match the relationship (formal / semi-formal / informal)

Mandatory Structure

All three bullet points in the task are **mandatory content requirements**. Missing one bullet drops the Task Achievement score.

Recommended paragraph mapping:

- **Para 1:** Opening + Bullet 1
- **Para 2:** Bullet 2
- **Para 3:** Bullet 3 + Closing

Sample Task

You have heard that one of your friends will be doing voluntary work at a festival. Write a letter to your friend. In your letter:

- ask about what type of festival your friend is volunteering at and when and where it will take place
- ask what your friend will have to do as part of the voluntary work
- ask if the organisers are still looking for more volunteers and how you can apply for the work

Model Answer (Band 7.0–7.5)

Dear Pat,

I was absolutely thrilled to hear that you will be volunteering at a festival this summer! It sounds like a wonderful experience, and I would love to find out more about it. Could you tell me what kind of festival it is — is it a music event, a cultural celebration, or something else entirely? I am also curious about when and where it will be held, as I imagine the location and timing would make quite a difference.

I would also love to know more about what the role actually involves. What sorts of tasks will you be expected to carry out as a volunteer? Are you working front-of-house, helping backstage, or something more logistical?

By the way, do you know if they still need more volunteers? I'd love to get involved if there's still a chance. Do you have any details on the application process?

Looking forward to hearing from you!

Best,

[Name]

Band Differentiation Analysis

Based on examiner-level comparison of three sample letters (Cristobal band 7 / Becky band 8 /

Jamie band 9):

Transition	What Separates the Bands
7 → 8	Eliminate irrelevant content; ensure all questions are on-task; add specific follow-up per bullet
8 → 9	Inject personal voice; use informal language naturally (contractions, rhetorical questions, light humour); make the reader feel the letter is from a real person
Ceiling breaker	Offer options within a question ("Is it music, food, or cultural performances?") — shows lexical range without adding word count

Disputed score note: Inventing facts not given in the prompt (e.g. assuming a location, date, or theme without being asked) is a Task Response failure. In a real exam this would cost more than one band point.

Examiner Criteria Weights (Task 1)

Criterion	Weight
Task Achievement	25%
Coherence & Cohesion	25%
Lexical Resource	25%
Grammatical Range & Accuracy	25%

4. Writing Task 2 — Essay

Task Parameters

- **Time allocation:** ~40 minutes
- **Minimum word count:** 250 words
- **Prompt type (example):** Opinion essay — "To what extent do you agree or disagree?"
- **Target length:** 280–320 words (sufficient to score full Task Response)

Positioning Strategy

For "to what extent do you agree or disagree?" prompts:

- **Avoid binary stances** — a partial agreement/nuanced position scores higher under Task Response and Coherence because it demonstrates analytical complexity.

- **Optimal position:** Acknowledge merits of one side, identify practical constraints, argue for a hybrid/nuanced conclusion.

Recommended Structure

Introduction	→ State position clearly (1 paragraph)
Body 1	→ Strongest argument for one side (1 paragraph)
Body 2	→ Counter-argument / practical constraints (1 paragraph)
Conclusion	→ Restate nuanced position (1 paragraph)

Sample Task

In many countries people have to pay for medical care, but some think that it should be a free service provided by the government. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

Model Answer (Band 7.5–8.0)

The question of whether healthcare should be funded by the state or paid for by individuals is one of the most debated issues in modern public policy. While I recognise that fully free medical services present significant financial challenges, I largely agree that access to healthcare is a fundamental right and that governments bear a primary responsibility to ensure it is available to all citizens regardless of income.

The strongest argument in favour of government-funded healthcare is one of equity. When medical treatment is tied to personal wealth, those in the lowest income brackets are effectively penalised for being ill. Chronic conditions, which disproportionately affect lower-income populations due to environmental and lifestyle factors, become financially ruinous without state support. Countries such as the United Kingdom, with its National Health Service, demonstrate that universal coverage is operationally viable at scale.

However, the financial reality of fully free healthcare is non-trivial. Unlimited demand for a zero-cost service creates pressure on public budgets that can lead to long waiting times, underinvestment in infrastructure, and shortages of specialist staff. A purely state-funded model without any co-payment mechanism risks being fiscally unsustainable, particularly in ageing populations where healthcare consumption per capita rises steeply.

In conclusion, the most defensible position is a mixed model: a publicly funded baseline ensuring universal access to essential care, supplemented by regulated private options for those who can afford them. This balances the equity imperative with fiscal sustainability, and is in fact the approach adopted by most high-performing healthcare systems globally.

Lexical Errors to Avoid (Italian Interference Patterns)

Incorrect	Correct	Note
demandato to	demandato that	False cognate — <i>esigere che</i> uses subjunctive, not

Incorrect	Correct	Note
		infinitive
provide equally	provide equally [X] / provide [X] equally	Adverb placement
very expensive	costly / prohibitively expensive	Avoid "very + basic adjective" at band 8+

5. Reading

Question Types: Sentence Completion

Core skill: Identifying paraphrase — the passage rephrases the stem with different vocabulary but equivalent meaning. Answers that match surface words without paraphrase detection indicate band 6–7 level reading.

Paraphrase Trap Examples

Stem phrase	Passage phrasing	Paraphrase mechanism
"excellent quality"	"high-quality teaching"	Adjective synonymy
"progression and development"	"progress"	Nominalisation collapse
"it is not possible to do"	"no [X] available"	Negation + structural change

▮ Navigating all three correctly indicates band 8–8.5 reading profile.

Band signal: Candidates who scan for matching words rather than meaning ceiling at band 6.5–7. True band 8 reading = meaning-first matching with tolerance for lexical variation.

6. Personal Performance Profile

Component	Estimated Band	Notes
Reading	8+	7/7 sentence completion with paraphrase detection — band 8–8.5 profile
Writing Task 1	7.0–7.5	Structure and content solid; register slightly too formal for informal letters

Component	Estimated Band	Notes
Writing Task 2	7.5-8.0	Task Response and Coherence at band 8 level; ceiling set by Lexical Resource
Listening	TBD	—
Speaking	TBD	—

Overall estimated range: 7.5 – 8.0

7. Key Error Patterns to Drill

Lexical Resource (Writing ceiling)

Italian syntactic interference showing up under time pressure — these are the primary blockers for the 7.5 → 8.0 jump:

- demanded to → demanded that
- provide equally → provide [X] equally / restructure
- very [basic adjective] → use precise synonyms (costly, substantial, negligible)

Task 1 Register Calibration

Current draft register is slightly more formal than optimal for informal letters. Actions:

- Add one speculative option per question: "Is it a music event, a food fair, or something cultural?"
- Add one piece of personal context per paragraph to simulate natural conversation
- Use contractions freely in informal letters (I'd, I've, it's)

Task 2 Positioning

- Never take a fully binary position on a "to what extent" prompt
- Lead with a clear directional stance in the introduction; qualify in body paragraphs; synthesise in conclusion
- Ensure every body paragraph has: claim → explanation → example/evidence

Appendix: Score Calculation Example

Listening: 8.0

Reading: 8.5
Writing: 7.5
Speaking: 7.5

Mean: 7.875 → rounds to 8.0 (Overall Band)

Rounding rule: nearest 0.5. Means of x.25 and x.75 round up; x.0 and x.5 are exact.

Last updated: June 2026 / Source: mock test sessions with feedback analysis